CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

OWNER-OPERATOR TRUCKING IN THE AI ERA

Driving is the easy half. The other half is owning a small business that happens to weigh forty tons.

★ TL;DR — Owner-operator trucking at a ~$120K median on this site's scale, enterable in 1–6 months if you already drive. The catch: that figure is revenue-shaped — fuel, repairs and empty miles eat owners who don't run their numbers. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

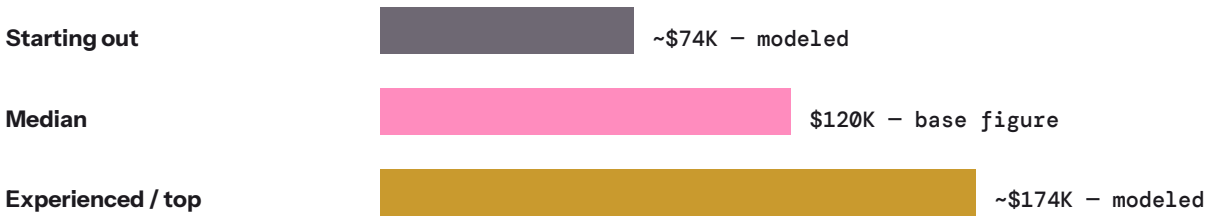
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$120K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- The truck is the employee and you are the company: dispatch, maintenance, sales and finance are all yours.
- Technology helps owners most — load boards and routing tools reward operators who use them well.
- Profit is arithmetic: cost per mile known to the cent, or the road decides your income for you.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Owner-Operator Trucking is a ~$120K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A OWNER-OPERATOR TRUCKING ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Driving your own loads, on lanes you chose
- ✓ Finding and negotiating freight with brokers and shippers
- ✓ Keeping the truck maintained, legal and rolling
- ✓ Bookkeeping: fuel, repairs, taxes and your own pay

Think: a one-person logistics company with a steering wheel.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Load boards, route and fuel optimization, and automated bookkeeping take the office layer. Smart owners let software run the desk so they can run the truck.	Negotiation, reputation with brokers and shippers, and the judgment to refuse bad freight. An owner is paid for decisions a company driver never has to make.

⚠ **One major engine failure in a slow month can erase a season. A repair reserve isn't a luxury in this business — it's the business surviving.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ You are your own dispatcher: lanes and home time are your calls ✓ The income ceiling belongs to you ✓ A real, sellable business asset grows under you	✗ Every risk — breakdowns, slow freight, late payments — is yours ✗ Admin at midnight after driving all day ✗ Truck payments arrive in slow weeks too

Good fit? An experienced driver with business discipline: you track numbers, maintain equipment and negotiate calmly.
Bad fit? You love driving but hate paperwork, or your savings cushion is zero.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — LEASE-PURCHASE THROUGH A CARRIER	DOOR B — YOUR OWN TRUCK, YOUR OWN BUSINESS
Run under a carrier's freight and authority while paying toward your own truck. Freight is steadier and setup is simpler — and the lease terms decide whether you're building equity or renting your own job.	Buy your truck, set up your business properly, and haul via brokers and direct shippers. Full control and full exposure: every good week is yours, and so is every bad one.

Smart move: Know your cost per mile to the cent before you accept load one. Owners don't fail on driving — they fail on arithmetic they never did.
Where you land after: A small multi-truck fleet, or a profitable niche — car hauling, refrigerated, heavy — with direct shipper contracts.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
RUN THE	CHOOSE THE	SET UP	LINE UP	RUN AND	OPTIMIZE THE

STEP 1 — Run the numbers first

FREE · TODAY

- Build your cost-per-mile sheet: fuel, payment, insurance, maintenance, your pay
- Decide the minimum rate your truck can accept and survive

STEP 2 — Choose the ownership route

MONTHS 1-2

- Compare lease-purchase terms against buying your own truck
- Read every clause about maintenance, escrow and exit

STEP 3 — Set up the business

MONTHS 1-3

- Business registration, insurance, bookkeeping and a separate business account
- Build your repair reserve before you build anything else

STEP 4 — Line up freight

MONTHS 2-4

- Broker relationships and load-board systems set up and tested
- Target lanes that fit your home-time and rate floor

STEP 5 — Run and track relentlessly

MONTHS 3-5

- Track revenue, cost and empty miles per load, every load
- Kill unprofitable lanes fast, however much you like driving them

STEP 6 — Optimize the operation

MONTHS 5-6

- Renegotiate insurance and recurring costs with a track record behind you
- Decide: stay a sharp one-truck operation or prepare truck number two

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: build your cost-per-mile spreadsheet with brutally honest numbers.

- Days 1–30: truck options and financing compared; business setup in motion.
- Days 31–60: insurance and accounts in place; first broker relationships opened.
- Days 61–90: first paid loads run under your own system, tracked to the cent.
- Day 90: you're operating as a business that drives — not a driver hoping it's a business.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ KNOW YOUR COST PER MILE. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.